

CAPTAIN COOL RETURNS, KINGS' HOPE, AND EMPTY SEATS: A ROLLERCOASTER ATMOSPHERE



SPORTSPICS / IPL

Our correspondents capture the essence of IPL's Chennai, Jaipur and New Chandigarh legs — **thrilling action** on the field and captivating stories beyond it.

Ahead of every IPL game featuring the Chennai Super Kings at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium, Victoria Hostel Road, connecting the stadium to the Chepauk train station, is cloaked in a sea of yellow. The street sees a fascinating blend of people – the well-dressed elite heading to the Kalaingar M. Karunanidhi Stand, and the middle-class masses queuing up from as early as 4:30 pm, eager to enter before the crowds build up.

For the game against Kolkata Knight Riders, there was an added buzz despite CSK's poor start to the 2025 season. M.S. Dhoni, the team's most successful captain and Chennai's adopted son, had returned to lead the side.

A few hours before the match, the Diary visited Hostel Road to capture the mood ahead of Dhoni's return as skipper. From middle-aged fans venting frustrations to groups of kids showing off their cricket knowledge, the mix was lively and amusing.

"The whole season will turn around with Dhoni back as captain," one yellow-clad fan shouted as he noticed the Diary with a microphone.

Some fans, however, were less eager to participate. A young woman, ducking under the camera frame, said, "Ayyo anna! Inga vanthathu veetla theriyadhu (Oh brother! My family doesn't know I'm here)."

181 balls later, the mood had changed. Fans were fuming, ranting to local news channels, and some had even started leaving before KKR began its chase of a meagre 104. Dhoni's return to captaincy hadn't worked out, but with Thala, hope for a turnaround never dies.

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